UPFRONT

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▶ SEEDS BILL

SOWING CHANGE

Over two decades in the making, a proposed seeds law tightens regulation, but forces a trade-off between sectoral formalisation and farmers' autonomy

By SONAL KHETARPAL

REGULATION vs RIGHTS

What the Seeds Bill seeks to achieve and why it is drawing concern

PROVISION: The law's objective is to "facilitate production and supply of quality seeds"

OBJECTION: Production/ supply are already addressed through existing programmes; the law should instead prioritise farmers' rights

PROVISION: Farmer defined as one who cultivates crops, directly or through others

OBJECTION: Narrow definition, excludes farmer-breeders, community seed banks etc.

PROVISION: Farmers may grow, sow, re-sow, save, use, exchange, share, sell seeds of registered varieties (except under a brand name)

OBJECTION: Nothing should restrict a farmer's right over any kind of farm seed

PROVISION: The Centre empowered to issue binding directions to states, determine policy

OBJECTION: Centralises authority, rule-making even on matters within the state domain

PROVISION: The Centre may regulate seed prices in "emergent situations"

OBJECTION: Limited to emergencies despite sustained concerns over rising seed costs

PROVISION: No explicit provision for paying compensation to farmers on crop failure

OBJECTION: Should provide a mechanism when registered seeds fail to perform